MASTER EVENT DOSSIER · 20 MARCH 2026

LotusHacks 2026 Master Brief

Current best full version: logistics, venue flow, event scale, judging signal, track strategy, networking priorities, credits, and tactical guidance for today.

SCALE	JUDGES	FORMAT	FLOW
1,000+ builders	**32 judges**	**36 hours**	**CIS → VNG**

Executive summary

Bottom line: LotusHacks is not reading like a casual student hackathon. It looks like a serious AI-builder room with strong sponsors, a heavyweight judge mix, and real ecosystem signal. The best path is a focused product, clear user, sharp demo, and deliberate networking—not maximum scope.

1. What is confirmed

ITEM	CURRENT BEST READ
Dates	March 20–22, 2026
Format	In-person, 36-hour hackathon
Hacking period	Friday 20:00 → Sunday 08:00
Check-in	CIS / Canadian International School Vietnam, roughly 4:00–6:00 PM
Workshop	Around 6:00 PM at CIS
Main venue later	VNG / VNG Group JSC
Team size	Up to 4; solo participation allowed

CIS LOCATION SIGNAL

Canadian International School Vietnam
No. 7 Road 23, Phu My Hung / Tan My Ward, District 7, Ho Chi Minh City

Online listings vary slightly, so sanity-check the map pin before leaving.

LATEST EMAIL CONFIRMATION

The latest LotusHacks Luma email subject confirms: **"Today's the day — check-in starts at 4PM."** The snippet references **Canadian International...** and also **VNG Group JSC**, reinforcing the CIS → VNG flow.

Arrival strategy: optimize for calm. Recommended arrival target is **4:15–4:30 PM**, not barely making the window.

2. Event scale and what it implies

PUBLIC/EVENT-SIDE SCALE SIGNALS

- Official site copy: **800+** builders
- Organizer-side LinkedIn post: **1,000+** builders
- LinkedIn post also says: **32 judges**
- Presented by LotusHacks × HackHarvard × GenAI Fund

PRACTICAL IMPLICATION

- This will likely feel crowded and competitive
- Attention is scarce; clarity matters more
- Weakly scoped ideas will die faster
- Networking can compound heavily if done well

3. Judge room signal

From the organizer-side LinkedIn post, the judging room includes people tied to:

OpenAI | Google | AWS | NVIDIA | McKinsey | Coca-Cola | Pharmacity | Phong Vu | Agora | VNGGames | FPT | TASCO | Startup founders

LIKELY REWARDED

- Technical credibility
- Real usefulness
- Fast demo comprehension
- Clear user / clear pain point
- Believable product direction

LIKELY PUNISHED

- Generic chatbot wrappers
- Over-scoped systems
- Vague “AI for X” language
- Pretty slides hiding weak demos
- Too many features, no sharp wedge

> **Strategic read:** this room probably rewards one tight believable product more than five clever but half-working ideas jammed together.

4. Track strategy

TRACK	SPONSOR	LIKELY BIAS	HOW TO PITCH
Enterprise	TinyFish	Operational usefulness, automation, ROI	Time saved, workflow reduction, actionability
Consumer / Consumer & Technology	AWS	Broad appeal, product potential, technical ambition	User appeal, polish, scale, repeat use
Social & Mobility	TASCO	Real-world coordination / movement / access	Practical impact, safety, access, city relevance
Edtech	Etest	Measurable learning or assessment value	Outcomes, feedback loops, progress measurement

5. Best project shape for today

YOUR BUILD SHOULD ANSWER

- Who is this for?
- What painful thing does it fix?
- Why is AI actually necessary here?
- Why now?
- What does the demo prove?

GOOD SHAPE

- One user
- One painful problem
- One sharp workflow
- One memorable demo moment
- One believable expansion path

Project filter: if the team cannot explain user, pain point, and 2-minute demo clearly, kill the idea early.

6. Team selection logic

GOOD TEAMMATE SIGNS

- Ships fast
- Scopes tightly
- Explains clearly
- Does not romanticize complexity

BAD TEAMMATE SIGNS

- Endless brainstorm loops
- “We should build a platform” energy
- Needs five features to feel smart
- Cannot name the user/problem

7. Networking priorities

> **Networking rule:** collect signal, not just contacts. You want useful conversations, not maximum business-card entropy.

PRIORITY	PERSON	WHY THEY MATTER	WHAT TO ASK
1	Valencia Queck	Already messaged you; inbound interest is highest leverage	Convert to a real in-person hello if relevant
2	Chelsea Ouyang	Accepted your LinkedIn invite; warm connection edge	Ask what projects or sponsor angles stand out in this room
3	Kai Yong Kang	GenAI Fund / ecosystem signal / organizer-side perspective	What kinds of AI products in SEA feel underbuilt right now?
4	Louis Vichy	OpenRouter / multi-model and AI product infra thinking	What are builders overcomplicating in AI architecture?
5	Gabriel Chua	OpenAI DevEx perspective on meaningful AI usage	What makes an AI demo feel real versus gimmicky?
6	Derek Zheng	Agora / realtime, voice, collaboration angle	What's a simple strong realtime use case that actually lands?

8. Background notes on key people

KAI YONG KANG

Public signals indicate Partner at **GenAI Fund**, with background in startup ecosystem and community building across Southeast Asia. High signal for market direction and what matters after the hackathon.

LOUIS VICHY

Public results confirm **cofounder of OpenRouter**. Useful if your product touches model routing, cost/performance tradeoffs, or practical AI infra design.

GABRIEL CHUA

From organizer post: **Developer Experience Engineer at OpenAI**. Likely cares about real developer usefulness, technical clarity, and meaningful AI integration.

DEREK ZHENG

From organizer post: **APAC Lead, Developer Relations at Agora**. Useful if your build has any voice, video, realtime communication, or collaboration layer.

9. Best questions to ask

JUDGES / FOUNDERS

- What kind of project stands out in a room like this?
- What do teams most often get wrong?
- What makes a demo memorable to you?

SPONSORS / DEVREL

- What's a strong but simple use of your tool that actually lands?
- What are builders overcomplicating?
- What makes a project feel real rather than forced?

10. Credits and sponsor value

ALREADY CLAIMED BY HONG

- OpenAI
- Exa
- OpenRouter
- Trae

STILL CONFIRMED FROM ORGANIZER OVERVIEW

- Agora
- ElevenLabs
- Manus AI
- Bright Data
- Qwen

11. Day-of checklist

BRING

- Laptop + charger
- Phone charger + power bank
- ID / passport
- Water bottle
- Toiletries / change of clothes if needed

LOCK BEFORE LEAVING

- Preferred track
- 1-sentence problem statement
- 30-second self-intro
- 2-minute pitch skeleton

12. Final tactical reminder

Win condition: build something coherent, meet 3–5 genuinely useful people, and leave with follow-up threads alive. Even if you do not win, the trip is worth it if it compounds.